Game Design Document: Chisel Town 1855

1. Engine & Architecture

To support both a persistent real-time isometric simulation and high-resolution first-person environments across web and desktop, Godot 4 is the optimal frontend engine. Its robust WebAssembly (Wasm) and WebGL export capabilities ensure smooth browser deployment.

For the underlying simulation, a decoupled architecture is highly recommended. Rather than trapping the complex multi-agent AI and procedural worldbuilding entirely within Godot, the core simulation logic should run on a dedicated backend written in Go or Rust. State syncing via WebRTC allows the mathematical sandbox to operate continuously and independently on a server, streaming the real-time simulation state to the Godot client. This ensures the heavy game engine only handles rendering and input, leaving the foundational mechanics lightweight and mathematically rigorous.

2. Core Gameplay Perspectives

The game relies on a jarring, asymmetric dual-perspective system to emphasize the thematic divide between control and agency.

- **The Terminal (Isometric God-Game):** The primary view. The player acts as Darren Hollus, overseeing the technologically suppressed 1855 facility from a modern surface terminal. The UI is clinical and data-driven. The player manages town cohesion, issues directives, and monitors subterranean pressure.
- **The Descent (First-Person Survival Horror):** The secondary view. The player assumes direct control of Carl. The camera shifts to a claustrophobic, high-fidelity, bottom-up perspective from within the terrarium. The UI vanishes, replaced by auditory hallucinations and oppressive environmental storytelling.

- **The Relay (Bob Sweeney's Role):** Bob operates from his cabin on the beached seaside, acting as the narrative and mechanical bridge. In the isometric view, Bob is the player's primary informant, translating the mass spectrometer data into actionable terminal alerts.
- **Playable Bob Sweeney (Tertiary Mechanic):** A first-person mode where the player briefly controls Bob. This perspective focuses on atmospheric exploration rather than survival, allowing the player to walk the perimeter of the simulation, interact with the surveillance equipment, and experience the eerie quiet of the "outside" edge of the terrarium.

3. The Social Engine (Generative Quest System)

Darren's attempt to bend Carl's "nature" through "nurture" relies on a complex, procedural social fabric rather than just physical weather or resource toggles. The decoupled Go/Rust backend supports a robust multi-agent AI system, allowing Darren to inject dynamic social groups into Chisel Town.

- **NPC Generation & Psychological Baselines:** Instead of hardcoded quests, the player spawns "families" or factions and assigns them hidden psychological weights—specific wants, fears, and resource dependencies (e.g., a family desperate for social mobility, or a faction deeply paranoid about the subterranean hum).
- **Procedural Worldbuilding & Emergent Quests:** Quests emerge organically from friction. If you restrict food and place a greedy faction next to Carl's dwelling, the system generates a conflict hook. Carl might be asked to steal, mediate, or betray a neighbor. The player orchestrates these variables to give Carl a sense of purpose, hoping the right combination of "nurture" overrides his inherited schizophrenia.
- **The Rustbowl as a Social Pressure Valve:** The mandatory dances at the Rustbowl are a mechanical tool to force interactions. When NPC hostilities peak or Carl's paranoia metrics spike, the player can mandate a dance to artificially inflate "cohesion" and scramble the town's social dynamics.
- **The Tragic Feedback Loop:** Because Carl's schizophrenia is perfectly inherited, the procedural quests always twist. A fabricated romance might provide temporary stability, but Carl's paranoia will eventually lead him to believe the partner is a spy. Every emergent storyline inevitably funnels Carl

back toward the whispering anomalies beneath the town, proving the futility of the experiment.

4. Act I: The Genesis of Grief (World-Building)

Act I functions as the tutorial and sandbox initialization, focusing on the maiden voyage of the experiment.

- **State of the World:** The simulation is largely empty. The physical town structures exist, but the population is sparse. The player (Darren) must learn the parameters of the environment and begin populating the town to establish a baseline for the experiment.
- **Clone 01 (C1):** C1 is decanted and dropped into the environment. Because the cloning process is perfect, C1 inherently possesses the exact same severe schizophrenia as the original Carl. Darren hopes this new manufactured "nurture" will change his fate.
- **The Hazard:** Darren does not yet fully understand the volatility of the physical hazard beneath the town. The player monitors the "goo"—the massive, pressurized subterranean reserve of raw crude oil and natural gas.
- **First-Person Integration:** The player occasionally drops into C1's first-person perspective to investigate the "murk." C1 interprets the pressurized gas moving behind the rocks as a living, primordial entity whispering to him.
- **The Act I Climax:** Despite Darren's initial attempts to control the environment, C1 digs into the chamber. The player watches helplessly as C1 is poisoned by the fumes and dies a violent, tragic death. The act ends with the player initiating a systemic reset to prepare Clone 02.

5. Act III: The Ouroboros (The Climax)

Act III represents the systemic collapse of the 25-year experiment. The UI is degrading, resources are depleted, and the "goo" has become a psychic graveyard echoing with the screams of 49 dead iterations of Carl.

- **Bob's Surrender:** Bob Sweeney reaches his breaking point. The player receives Bob's final transmission, detailing his lamentation over the loss of his partner, Sarah C., and his total disillusionment with Darren's cruelty.

- **Playable Bob Sequence:** The player drops into Bob's first-person perspective. The objective is to manually shut down the monitoring machines. The player walks Bob out of the seaside cabin and climbs the artificial hills toward the simulation's boundaries, heading "up" to accept his fate.
- **Carl 50's Descent:** The final sequence forces the player into Carl 50's first-person view. Carl 50 possesses phantom memories of dying 49 different ways. The player navigates the dark, high-res caverns beneath the Rustbowl, guided by the whispers.
- **The Ignition:** In the deepest chamber, the player (as Carl) uses 1855 mining explosives to ignite the highly pressurized cavern of crude oil.
- **The End State:** The camera snaps back to the isometric terminal view as the catastrophic explosion tears through the UI. The physical shockwave travels up the shafts, obliterating the terrarium and detonating Darren's observation terminal on the surface, incinerating the player's avatar.